

THE SUCCESSFUL VETERAN

The Transition Workbook

A companion workbook to The Successful Veteran — the modern guide to networking, AI, and landing the job.

Andrew Miller

Author, *The Successful Veteran*

THESUCCESSFULVET.COM

How To Use This Workbook

Welcome. Whether you're the one who served or the spouse who moved every two years alongside them, if you're holding this workbook, you're somewhere in a transition — a few years out, a few months out, or already sitting in the civilian side of it wondering why nobody handed you a map. This is that map, condensed.

The Successful Veteran is a full playbook: chapters on knowing yourself, networking, choosing a career pathway and the certifications that actually matter, building a resume, and preparing for the interview. This workbook pulls the exercises out of that book and puts them in front of you as worksheets — the same standards, the same information, reduced to what you can fill in with a pen this week.

WHAT THIS WORKBOOK COVERS

- **Chapter 1 — Know Yourself.** Your transition timeline, your no-compromise boundaries, your elevator pitch.
- **Chapter 2 — Network & Brand.** LinkedIn, informational interviews, the relationship tracker.
- **Chapter 3 — Certifications & Pathways.** How to pick one that matters, mapped by industry, and who pays for it.
- **Chapter 4 — Resume & Cover Letter.** A build-it-yourself template and the company-first cover letter structure.
- **Chapter 5 — Interview Preparation.** The STAR method, story templates, and a pre-interview checklist.

HOW TO USE IT

- Work through it in order. Chapter 1 is the foundation everything else is built on — don't skip to the resume.
- Every worksheet has an AI prompt where one is useful. Open ChatGPT, Copilot, or Claude, fill in the brackets, and paste the output back into the workbook.
- This is a start, not the whole book. Where a section is condensed, it points back to the matching chapter in The Successful Veteran for the full version.

"Don't panic. The transition is stressful, but it doesn't have to be hard."

All core content in this workbook is free, as is everything at thesuccessfulvet.com. The book goes deeper on every chapter here, and a portion of every worksheet in this workbook is drawn directly from it.

Five Stages, One Cycle

Transitioning out of the military — whether you're the veteran or the spouse building a portable career around it — is not one decision. It's five, taken roughly in order. Miss the order and you end up building a resume before you know what you want it to say. This workbook follows the cycle below, one chapter per stage.

01**Know Yourself**

Define your no-compromise areas and your elevator pitch before you touch a resume.

**02****Network & Brand**

Build LinkedIn, run informational interviews, grow your relationship tracker.

**03****Certify & Choose**

Pick one advanced certification that matches a real, verified demand.

**04****Resume & Cover Letter**

Translate your experience into quantified, civilian-facing language.

**05****Interview & Land**

Prepare STAR stories, rehearse out loud, follow up, get the offer.

This cycle isn't a strict one-way street. Networking continues after you land the job. Certifications get revisited every time you consider a pivot. But for a first pass through your transition, work top to bottom.

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CHAPTER 1

Know Yourself & Own Your Transition

Before the resume, before LinkedIn, before a single application — define what you actually want and learn to say it in 30 seconds. Everything else in this workbook builds from this chapter.

Your Transition Timeline

Transition timelines aren't a strict formula — whether you have three years or three months, every veteran or spouse can transition well. Use this as your master checklist and adjust to your own clock.

18–36 Months Out *Research, not applications.*

- ☐ Talk to your family. Get their feedback before you decide anything.
- ☐ Research industries or career fields that interest you.
- ☐ Create a LinkedIn account and start building your network.
- ☐ Conduct informational interviews.
- ☐ Determine your “best fit” (see the No-Compromise Framework, next page).
- ☐ Explore SkillBridge or Career Skills Program opportunities.
- ☐ Identify a mentor — MilMentor is a free place to start.

12–18 Months Out *Start finishing.*

- ☐ Finish degrees; complete civilian certifications you identified as worth it — Onward to Opportunity (IVMF) is a strong place to start.
- ☐ Apply to SkillBridge, fellowships, and Leader Development Programs.
- ☐ Utilize career transition services — Wounded Warrior Project® (WWP) Warriors to Work® and USO Pathfinder both work with veterans and spouses.
- ☐ Start your personal brand / strength statement.
- ☐ Make an appointment with your local TAP counselor.

6–12 Months Out *Execute.*

- ☐ Draft your master resume.
- ☐ Attend TAP workshops and veteran & spouse outreach events.
- ☐ Complete certifications or degrees — finish what you started.
- ☐ Get a professional headshot — Portraits for Patriots offers them free.
- ☐ Optional: apply to tech fellowships — Microsoft Software & Systems Academy (MSSA), Salesforce Military, AWS re/Start.
- ☐ Spouses: apply for the SpouseWorks Fellowship — 12-week paid fellowships.

3–6 Months Out *Apply and network in earnest.*

- ☐ Submit your pre-discharge disability claim (BDD or DRC) — service members only.
- ☐ Resume review — tailor it for every specific job.
- ☐ Network with industry recruiters and hiring managers.
- ☐ Attend career fairs, prepared.

90 Days or Less *Apply, don't start.*

- ☐ Ensure your DD-214 is correct (service members) or your dependent ID and records are current (spouses).
- ☐ Start applying for jobs with a tailored resume.
- ☐ Continue networking — information interviews, practice interviews.

COMPETITIVENESS

Always keep growing — complete as many advanced, relevant certifications as you reasonably can. Credentials compensate for the civilian experience you don't have yet.

Talk To Your Family First

The transition is not a solo decision if you have a family depending on it. This conversation goes first, before you research a single job posting.

QUESTIONS TO ASK YOUR FAMILY

- What does a good life look like for us on the other side of this? What are we afraid of?
- Are we open to relocating? If so, where — and where is a hard no? Weigh climate/temperature, housing costs, whether the state taxes disability or retirement pay, how veteran-friendly the community actually is, and whether it's a compact state for your professional license.
- What income do we need, realistically, versus what we'd like to have?
- Whose career or schooling has to be part of this decision besides mine?
- What does the first 90 days after separation need to look like for our family?

REALISTIC FINANCES — HAVE TO MAKE VS. WANT TO MAKE

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
What is your current monthly budget?	
What changes in cost of living where you're headed — housing, insurance, taxes?	
What is the minimum you HAVE to make to sustain your family?	
What would you WANT to make, given your experience and target field?	

DON'T PANIC

The transition is stressful, but it doesn't have to be hard. Every veteran or spouse can transition well — whether you're starting this conversation three years out or three months out.

What Matters Most

Before you write a single no-compromise area, get honest about what you actually want out of work — not what looks good on paper.

RANK WHAT MATTERS, 1 (LEAST) TO 5 (MOST)

FACTOR	1	2	3	4	5
Location					
Salary					
Remote, hybrid, in person					
Security and stability					
Work-life balance (hours per week)					
Future role dynamic (managing others, part of a team, solo work)					

Carry your top 2–3 ranked factors straight into the No-Compromise Framework on the next page — that's exactly what it's built from.

The No-Compromise Framework

A no-compromise area is a hard line — a condition that, if a role doesn't meet it, you walk. Most people don't have any, which is why most transitions feel reactive instead of intentional. Three to five, agreed with your family, eliminates most of the decision fatigue in a job search.

WHAT MAKES ONE WORK

- **Specific and testable.** “Good work-life balance” isn't testable. “Average workweek under 45 hours” is.
- **Survives the offer.** If a signing bonus would make you fold on it, it's a preference, not a boundary.
- **Co-signed by your family.** If they haven't agreed, the line moves under pressure.

PRESSURE-TEST AGAINST FOUR DIMENSIONS

LIFESTYLE & COMP

- ☐ Total comp floor (base + bonus + match)
- ☐ Maximum weekly hours you'll accept
- ☐ Remote / hybrid / on-site policy

ROLE & FUNCTION

- ☐ Individual contributor vs. people-manager
- ☐ Title floor — the level you won't go below

LOCATION & GEOGRAPHY

- ☐ Specific city, region, or country
- ☐ Commute cap, proximity to family

COMPANY & SECTOR

- ☐ Industry — required, or open?
- ☐ Stability vs. equity upside

WRITE YOUR TOP 3-5

YOUR AREA	WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOU, AND WHY (ONE SENTENCE)
Area 1	
Area 2	
Area 3	
Area 4 (optional)	

WATCH OUT

More than five areas means none of them are actually non-negotiable — force-rank and cut. And if you're separating with no degree or certification, holding a \$150K floor on day one is wishful thinking, not strategy.

Build Your Elevator Pitch

Once you know what you want, you need to say — in 30 seconds, to a stranger, without notes — who you are and why a company should want you. It's built from one foundation: the Strength Statement.

STEP 1: THE STRENGTH STATEMENT

ONE sentence that captures your single biggest professional strength. Not three things, not a skills list — the one thing you want remembered if they forget everything else. It names a specific domain ("logistics operations," not "leadership"), signals scale, and survives an 8-second read-aloud test.

This sentence is not your elevator pitch on its own — it's the first of three steps below. Get it right first, because the other two are built on top of it.

"I'm a logistics operator who's built and run high-tempo supply chains across three combat deployments and now want to do the same in commercial supply chain."

BUILD YOUR PITCH — THREE STEPS, 30 SECONDS TOTAL

BLOCK	FILL IN
Step 1. Strength Statement One sentence, your biggest strength — the starting point, not the finished pitch	
Step 2. Experience & Goals One proof point + where you're headed	
Step 3. What You Bring The trait that makes you different, tailored per conversation	

PRACTICE PROTOCOL

- ☐ Record yourself delivering it on your phone. Cut anything that sounds rehearsed.
- ☐ Deliver it cold to three people this week — a networking event, a vet meetup, a coffee chat.
- ☐ Expect polite silence early. Every pitch is data. Most veterans' fifth version is twice as strong as their first.

IF YOU ONLY DO ONE THING

Get the Strength Statement to one sentence — but don't stop there. It's step one of the pitch, not the pitch itself. Your resume, your LinkedIn headline, and your interview opener all draw from it, then build past it with Steps 2 and 3.

CHAPTER 2

Network, LinkedIn & Your Brand

Most jobs are filled through people, not job boards. This chapter builds the profile, the habits, and the tracker that make networking work instead of feeling like a chore.

Why Networking Is the Job Search

Networking isn't a phase you complete before the "real" job search starts — it is the job search. A posted job on a company site or LinkedIn already has hundreds of applicants competing on a resume alone. A referral, a warm introduction, or a name a hiring manager already recognizes skips most of that line.

TWO THINGS TO DO BEFORE YOU START

- ☐ **Claim LinkedIn Premium.** Free for one year for veterans and military spouses — unlocks LinkedIn Learning, including certification prep courses.
- ☐ **Search on LinkedIn, apply on the company site.** Company career pages list veteran- and spouse-specific programs and fellowships that rarely surface in a LinkedIn search. LinkedIn finds the company; the company's site shows you the door built for you.

THE HABIT THAT WORKS

Networking is not a one-time event before you apply. It's a habit you run weekly, before you need it. Set a standing goal — two informational interviews or coffee chats a week — and hold it whether or not you're actively job hunting yet. By the time you need the network, it already exists.

WHY IT WORKS

Profiles with a professional photo get more connection requests, more profile views, and more messages. Many recruiters won't accept a connection request from an empty profile — the audit on the next page fixes that first.

The LinkedIn Profile Audit

The full 25-point audit lives in the LinkedIn Overhaul Checklist at thesuccessfulvet.com. Here are the checkpoints that move the needle fastest.

PHOTO & BANNER

- ☐ Clear, professional headshot — solid background, no selfies.
- ☐ Banner customized, not the default gray bar.
- ☐ No headshot? Portraits for Patriots offers free, portfolio-quality headshots to veterans and spouses.

HEADLINE & ABOUT

- ☐ Headline is civilian language, under 120 characters, results-focused.
- ☐ About section is first person, 200–300 words: what you deliver, what you're known for, what's next.

EXPERIENCE & SKILLS

- ☐ Every role has 2–4 quantified bullets, not a duty list.
- ☐ Skills section matches the exact language from your target job postings.
- ☐ Verbs are outcome-focused — not 'led,' 'managed,' 'oversaw,' or 'directed.'

NETWORK & PROOF

- ☐ At least 2 recommendations from peers, supervisors, or civilian contacts.
- ☐ Profile URL customized to [linkedin.com/in/yourname](https://www.linkedin.com/in/yourname).
- ☐ Actively connecting with 2–3 new people in your target industry each week.

AI PROMPT — ABOUT SECTION WRITER

"I am a transitioning U.S. [branch] veteran with [MOS/Rating/AFSC] and [X years] of service, targeting [role/industry]. Write my LinkedIn About section in first person, 200–300 words. Include what I've delivered, what I'm known for, what I'm looking for next, and how to reach me. No military jargon. No 'led,' 'managed,' 'oversaw,' or 'directed.'"

AI PROMPT — INFORMATIONAL CHAT REQUEST

"I am a transitioning U.S. [branch] veteran targeting [role/industry]. Write a short LinkedIn connection note (under 300 characters) and a follow-up message to send once [name/title] at [company] accepts, asking for a brief 15–20 minute informational chat to learn about their role, team, and industry — not a job, referral, or resume review. Keep both warm, specific, and respectful of their time."

Informational Interviews & Your Tracker

Come prepared with a reason for the conversation. What are you gaining from it — a read on the culture, the certifications that actually matter, an honest view of the day-to-day?

SAMPLE QUESTIONS

- What does the day-to-day look like in your role?
- What's the work-life balance like — hours, remote options, PTO?
- How would you describe the culture here? Is it military-friendly?
- What certifications, skills, or education would make me more competitive?
- Which certifications turned out not to matter?

WHAT THIS IS NOT

An informational interview is not a disguised ask for a job, a referral, or a resume review. It's a conversation to learn about the role, the industry, and the company — nothing more. Ask for help and you'll get a guarded, careful answer. Ask to learn and people open up.

ALWAYS END WITH “THE ASK”

Is there anyone else you'd recommend I talk to? Leave it open-ended. This is the single highest-leverage question in the entire conversation — it's how a network compounds instead of staying flat.

YOUR RELATIONSHIP TRACKER

NAME	HOW I KNOW THEM	LAST CONTACT	NEXT FOLLOW-UP

This isn't a one-time document. Keep it running — it becomes more valuable the longer you maintain it, well past your first civilian job.

Your Personal Brand

Your personal brand is the throughline across your resume, LinkedIn, elevator pitch, and interview answers — the same story, told consistently, everywhere someone might encounter you.

CONSISTENCY CHECK

- ☐ My Strength Statement (Chapter 1) matches the language in my LinkedIn headline.
- ☐ My LinkedIn About section and my resume summary tell the same story, not two different ones.
- ☐ The skills I list on LinkedIn are the same skills I can back up with a STAR story in Chapter 5.
- ☐ I sound like myself — if a sentence reads like someone else's profile, I rewrite it.

WHERE YOUR BRAND SHOWS UP

TOUCHPOINT	WHAT IT NEEDS TO SAY
LinkedIn headline	Core skill + secondary skill + result you deliver.
Resume summary	What you deliver, not what you've done — 2–4 sentences.
Elevator pitch	Strength statement, spoken, under 30 seconds.
Interview opener	The 2-minute confidence brief from your pre-interview checklist.

BE PREPARED TO HEAR NO

It takes time and feedback to develop an effective brand. Every “no” after a pitch is data, not a verdict — use it to sharpen the next version.

CHAPTER 3

Certifications & Career Pathways

The certification industry doesn't care if you get hired — it cares if you enroll. This chapter shows you how to verify a certification is worth earning, which ones map to which industries, and who will pay for it.

How to Choose a Pathway

One advanced certification in a field that actually hires veterans and spouses beats five entry-level ones nobody asked for. Before you spend a single hour studying, do two things. Here's the first.

FIRST – CONNECT WITH SOMEONE IN THE FIELD

A coffee chat or informational interview. Ask what certifications actually matter in their job and which ones hiring managers care about. The answer usually surprises people – the cert everyone assumes is mandatory turns out to be optional, and the one nobody posts about is the one recruiters screen for first. Use the same conversation to ask about the role itself – what they actually do day to day.

That conversation costs you 15 minutes and a LinkedIn request. Skipping it costs you a year and wasted money.

LINKEDIN CONNECTION REQUEST

"Hi [Name], I'm a transitioning veteran/military spouse exploring [industry/role]. I noticed you've done [specific thing]. Would you be open to a 15-minute conversation about your path – specifically which certifications would be best when applying for similar roles?"

THREE WAYS TO VERIFY IT'S WORTH EARNING

- ☐ **Pull three real job postings** in the exact role you want. Read the required section, not "nice to have." If a certification appears in all three, it's real.
- ☐ **Run the informational interview.** Ask directly: what certifications would make me more competitive? Then ask the question almost nobody asks – which certifications turned out not to matter?
- ☐ **Track the pattern.** One answer is a data point. Three or four people naming the same credential is a pattern worth six months of your life.

How to Choose a Pathway, Continued

Second — steal this AI prompt, but run it in a tool with live web search (ChatGPT or Claude with search turned on, Perplexity, Copilot) so it's pulling from real postings instead of guessing off old training data.

AI PROMPT — VERIFY CERTIFICATIONS WITH LIVE SEARCH

"I'm targeting a [specific job title] role in the [industry] field. Search for at least 15 current job postings for this exact title and pull the certifications listed in each one's required or preferred qualifications. Tell me: (1) which certification shows up most often, with the exact certifying body and credential name, and how many of the 15 postings named it, (2) the advanced or senior-level certification people in this role typically earn next, (3) any complementary certification that shows up alongside it. If you don't have live search access, tell me that directly instead of guessing, and give me the exact search terms to run myself on LinkedIn and Indeed."

That last line matters. An AI tool without search will answer either way confidently, and a confident wrong answer is worse than no answer. Make it show its work or tell you it can't.

AI PROMPT — DECODE A SINGLE POSTING

"Here's a job posting: [paste]. List every certification, license, or credential mentioned. Separate them into 'required' and 'preferred.' For each, tell me what it signals to an employer and how long it typically takes to earn. Then tell me honestly whether this looks like a role where the certification is a hard gate or a nice-to-have."

Now you can plan ahead and get the certifications that matter. Make your time count — become competitive, not just a badge collector.

YOUR NOTES

SkillBridge: Your Best Transition Tool

“If you do one single thing to improve your transition, it should be SkillBridge.”

SkillBridge is the Department of Defense program that lets you work as a full-time intern at a civilian company for up to 180 days before you separate — while still drawing your full military pay and benefits. The employer doesn't pay you; the military still does. Roughly 88% of SkillBridge participants receive a job offer at the end of the program.

WHY IT'S THE HIGHEST-LEVERAGE PROGRAM AVAILABLE

- ☐ Real civilian work experience on your resume, months before you separate.
- ☐ A foot in the door at a target company — often converting straight to an offer.
- ☐ Open to any rank, enlisted or officer, at any point in your timeline.

HOW TO APPLY

- Start at skillbridge.osd.mil and research the program and partner companies.
- Talk to your Transition Office or Education Office for enrollment specifics.
- Give your command as much lead time as possible — SkillBridge is typically only denied when notification comes too late.
- No local Program Manager? Submit a Contact Us request directly on the SkillBridge site.

COMMON MISCONCEPTION

Nobody in your chain of command can arbitrarily deny a SkillBridge request without cause. Know the regulation before you accept a “no.”

Spouse reading this? SkillBridge is only open to the service member. Your equivalent free-training runway is SpouseWorks, SECO, and the Transition Assistance Programs page later in this chapter.

Fellowships: Paid Experience First

Fellowships are SkillBridge's cousin — structured, often paid placements with a host organization that build real civilian experience before you separate. Several run through SkillBridge itself; a few stand entirely apart.

HIRING OUR HEROES — CORPORATE FELLOWSHIP PROGRAM

A DoD SkillBridge program: 12 weeks, matched with a host company based on your skills and preferences, five days a week on the job plus a Friday professional-development huddle. Runs three cohorts a year at installations and host cities nationwide. Must be on active duty within 180 days of transition. Free.

HIRING OUR HEROES — SKILLS-BASED FELLOWSHIPS

Same 12-week SkillBridge structure, built for non-degreed transitioning service members targeting skilled trades, technology, administration, or finance. Military spouses are eligible to participate as well.

NASA SERVICE MEMBER FELLOWSHIPS

An authorized SkillBridge and Operation Warfighter partner. Roles span engineering, IT/cybersecurity, business, and science across NASA centers nationwide, including hybrid and remote. NASA doesn't post vacancies — you apply into a candidate pool that sponsoring centers review for a mission-need match. No job guarantee, but you leave with "NASA Fellow" on your resume.

UNITEDHEALTH GROUP — MILITARY FELLOWSHIP PROGRAM

Runs in partnership with DoD SkillBridge and Hiring Our Heroes across 33 job families (business, finance, clinical operations, tech, project management). Open to transitioning service members with 120–180 days remaining, and to spouses accepted into the Hiring Our Heroes Military Spouse Fellowship. Screening typically starts 4–10 months before separation.

HOOVER INSTITUTION VETERAN FELLOWSHIP PROGRAM (VFP)

A different kind of fellowship — not a work placement. A year-long, non-residential, project-based program for post-9/11 veterans (active duty within the past 25 years), pairing you with Hoover's policy research network through roughly five in-person engagements plus virtual sessions across the year. Built for veterans interested in policy, writing, or public affairs.

SPOUSES

The Hiring Our Heroes Military Spouse Fellowship is a paid, roughly 6–9 week hands-on placement with a host company — no SkillBridge or service-member sponsorship required. It's the fellowship equivalent of everything above, built specifically for you.

Leader Development Programs

Do this. Next to SkillBridge or a placement service like RecruitMilitary, this is the least-known, highest-leverage tool in your entire transition.

You've amassed years of leadership, strategy, team development, and risk mitigation — soft skills the civilian market pays for. The only thing missing is years of civilian job market experience. Leader Development Programs (also called leadership or management development programs, or named for a specific function like a finance development program) exist to close exactly that gap: structured tracks that rotate you through multiple parts of a company and groom you for an entry-level management role.

HOW THEY'RE USUALLY STRUCTURED

- ☐ 30 days of new-hire training to start.
- ☐ 3–5 rotations, each lasting 9–12 months, often in a new location and function — finance, logistics, operations — so you understand the whole company, not just one piece.
- ☐ Conditional offers frequently land 9–15 months before your start date, which means you can bypass the usual scramble to find a job three months from ETS.
- ☐ Relocation is typically covered for every move — some companies will even buy your house if it doesn't sell.

WHAT THEY TYPICALLY PAY

EDUCATION LEVEL	STARTING	AT COMPLETION
Bachelor's degree	\$75,000–\$90,000	Up to \$120,000+
MBA or master's degree	\$115,000–\$130,000 + stock/bonus	Up to \$160,000+

A FEW PROGRAMS TO START RESEARCHING

Bachelor's-level: Amazon Military Pathways · Lockheed Martin Early Offer Pathway · Johnson & Johnson Operations Military Veterans LDP · Chick-fil-A · Home Depot Supply Chain Management Program · Honeywell Early Career Programs · Eaton · Textron.

MBA/master's-level: GE · Chewy Accelerated Operations Leadership Program · Citi · Michelin Global Leadership Program.

FULL LIST

The complete list of Leader Development Programs, broken out by degree level and industry, is in the Appendix of The Successful Veteran.

Certifications by Industry

Every industry has its own ladder of certifications. Most of it is noise until you know which rung you're actually standing on.

FIELD	ENTRY	ADVANCED
Human Resources	aPHR or SHRM-CP	PHR, SPHR, or SHRM-SCP once you have real HR experience behind it.
Logistics & Supply Chain	CPIM (planning & inventory)	CSCP (end-to-end) or CLTD (logistics, transportation, distribution) through ASCM. Buying side: CPSM or CPSD.
Information Technology	CompTIA A+, Network+, Security+, Cloud+	AWS Cloud Practitioner → Solutions Architect, Azure Fundamentals → Administrator/Architect Expert, or Google Associate Cloud Engineer. Oracle also runs a free certification program just for veterans — Cloud Infrastructure Foundations, Database Cloud Administrator, and Database SQL.
Cybersecurity	Security+ or Certified in Cybersecurity (CC)	CySA+, PenTest+ (penetration testing), the GIAC ladder (GSEC, GCIH, GCED, GSOC, GISP), then CISSP, CISM, CISA, CCSP, or CASP+. Targeting cloud security or ethical hacking specifically? Look at GCPN (cloud penetration testing), GCSA (cloud security automation), or CEH — the name recruiters actually search for.
Artificial Intelligence	Google AI Essentials or Azure AI Fundamentals	AWS Certified Machine Learning – Specialty or Google's ML certification track.
Project Management	Google PM Certificate, CAPM, or Project+	PMP. Process-focused alternative: Lean Six Sigma, Green Belt through Black Belt.
Business	ECBA or Lean Six Sigma Green Belt	CBAP or Six Sigma Black Belt. Salesforce Certified Administrator — free through Salesforce Military if your target runs on Salesforce.
Accounting	QuickBooks ProAdvisor or Certified Bookkeeper	Enrolled Agent (EA), then CPA or CMA. Military finance background? Look at CGFM.
Teaching	Troops to Teachers	Free guidance through state licensure — no education background required, stipends common for high-need subjects.

RULE OF THUMB

If you already have real operational experience in the field, skip the entry-level badge. It undersells you.

WHICH FIELD FITS YOU?

AI PROMPT – CERTIFICATION FIT FINDER

"I'm a U.S. [branch] veteran with [MOS/Rating/AFSC] experience and these responsibilities: [paste 3–5 duties]. I'm considering a pivot into [field]. Based on my actual experience, which entry-level certification am I already past? Which mid-level or advanced certification would most directly translate my experience into a civilian title? Name the certifying body and credential exactly."

Treat the output as a hypothesis, not an answer — the job posting and the informational interview from the previous page are what confirm or kill it.

The MOS Translation Worksheet

Your military specialty is not a liability — it's a resume written in code. Three steps to translate it. **Spouse without a military code of your own?** Skip to the civilian-experience version of Step 2 below, or head straight to this chapter's certification pathways — most map to skills, not a service record.

STEP 1 — YOUR TOP 5 MILITARY DUTIES

List them exactly as you'd write them in an NCOER, EVAL, OPR, or FITREP. Military language is fine here — you'll translate in Step 2.

STEP 2 — TRANSLATE TO CIVILIAN LANGUAGE

EXAMPLE

Military: "Served as the primary 92A responsible for managing PLL and shop stock in a forward-deployed environment."

Civilian: "Drove 99% parts availability across a remote operating location supporting a 400-person team, with \$1.2M of mission-critical inventory tracked to a 0.3% loss rate over 18 months."

AI PROMPT

"I am a transitioning U.S. [branch] veteran with [MOS/Rating/AFSC] experience. Here are my top 5 military duties: [paste]. Translate each into civilian business language for a [target role]. Use active voice; do not use 'led,' 'managed,' 'oversaw,' or 'directed' — show what changed, improved, or was delivered."

STEP 3 — BUILD YOUR LINKEDIN HEADLINE

Formula: [Core Skill] + [Secondary Skill] + [Result You Deliver] + [Years / Industry]

Full 20-code crosswalk tables for Army, Navy, Air Force, Marine Corps, and Coast Guard are in the MOS Translation Worksheet download at thesuccessfulvet.com.

Who Pays: Free & Discounted Funding

Before you pay out of pocket for a certification, check whether one of these covers it.

FREE, FULL STOP

- ☐ Onward to Opportunity (IVMF, Syracuse) — one free certification exam per participant.
- ☐ FedVTE — 850+ hours of free cybersecurity training.
- ☐ SANS VetSuccess Academy — 100% scholarship, GIAC certifications included.
- ☐ Microsoft Software & Systems Academy — free 17-week training with job placement.
- ☐ Coursera Career Academy for Veterans — free Google, IBM, and Meta certificates.
- ☐ VetsinTech — free cyber, cloud, and programming training.
- ☐ AWS re/Start & AWS Skill Builder — free cloud training.
- ☐ Salesforce Military — free certification, plus a fellowship.
- ☐ (ISC)² Certified in Cybersecurity (CC) — free for your first year.
- ☐ Troops to Teachers & USO Pathfinder — free guidance and certification scholarships.
- ☐ Helmets to Hardhats — free placement into building-trades apprenticeships (electrical, plumbing, carpentry, and more).

DISCOUNTED OR REIMBURSED

- ☐ SpouseWorks (formerly MyCAA) — up to \$4,000 for eligible spouses.
- ☐ PMI Military Spouse Program — fee waivers on CAPM and PMP.
- ☐ NASM (National Academy of Sports Medicine) — discounted personal training and fitness certifications for veterans and spouses.
- ☐ Edith Nourse Rogers STEM Scholarship — up to \$30,000.
- ☐ CyberCorps: Scholarship for Service — up to \$34,000 a year.
- ☐ GI Bill Chapters 33/35 — up to \$2,000 reimbursed per approved test.
- ☐ ArmyIgnitED (and sister branch platforms) — tuition assistance, no service obligation.

DON'T FORGET

LinkedIn Premium is free for a year for veterans and spouses, and unlocks LinkedIn Learning's full certification prep library.

TRADE SCHOOL FUNDING IS EXPANDING

Your GI Bill on-the-job-training and apprenticeship benefit already covers skilled trades, and the Dole Act plus newer VA policy updates continue widening access to trade and vocational programs. Common VA-approved paths include welding and metalworking, HVAC installation and repair, CDL truck driving, electrical and plumbing apprenticeships, cosmetology and barbering (at approved schools), LPN/RN nursing programs, OSHA safety certifications, and aviation and flight training (up to the tuition cap). Confirm current guidance and which programs qualify directly at va.gov before you enroll.

Transition Assistance Programs

The federal TAP program is the floor, not the ceiling. These optional, nonprofit programs go deeper and stay with you longer. They're free, they don't conflict with each other, and each gives you something different — apply to more than one.

PROGRAM	WHAT IT OFFERS	BEST FOR
Hiring Our Heroes	Career fairs, fellowships, corporate mentorship, free certifications.	Structured corporate networking.
Wounded Warrior Project® (WWP) Warriors to Work®	Free, personalized career coaching, resume help, and employer connections.	Warriors and family members alike.
American Corporate Partners (ACP)	12-month, 1-on-1 mentorship with a senior civilian professional.	A year-long civilian mentor relationship.
Candorful	Free live interview practice with real feedback.	Rehearsing out loud before the interview that counts.
VetsinTech	Tech-specific training, fellowships, employer matching.	Veterans targeting technology careers.
The Honor Foundation	Highly selective career transition curriculum.	Special operations community.
FourBlock	Cohort-based career-readiness program across 20+ cities.	Peer cohort support within 12 months of transition.
VETS2INDUSTRY	Free resource library, mentorship, employer access.	Curated, vetted resources in one place.
IVMF (Syracuse University)	O2O, Veteran EDGE, V-WISE, EBV, and more under one institute.	Any specific need — a cert, a business idea, a job lead.
50 Strong	Regional hiring events connecting veterans directly with employers.	Face-to-face hiring events outside the major national circuit.
Boots to Books	Free course preparing veterans for the academic side of college before day one.	Veterans and spouses heading to community college on the GI Bill.
MilMentor	Free 1-on-1 mentorship matching veterans and spouses with civilian professionals.	A mentor matched specifically to your target industry.

Full program directory, including SkillBridge partner companies and leadership development programs by industry, is in Appendix B and C of *The Successful Veteran*.

CHAPTER 4

Resume & Cover Letter

Your resume comes last for a reason — it only works once you know your fit, your pathway, and how to translate your experience. Here's how to build one that survives an ATS and a human being.

The Two Rules & the “So What” Test

Even with the best credentials, a weak resume stalls a transition. Two rules run through everything in this section.

RULE 1 – DON’T PANIC

Your resume is not a duty list. It’s a translated, quantified case for why you’re the answer to a specific job posting. It gets built once as a master document, then tailored per application — not rewritten from scratch each time.

RULE 2 – DON’T PAY

Free, high-quality resume review exists specifically for veterans and military spouses through Hire Heroes USA, RecruitMilitary, and the USO, among others. You should never have to pay for a resume review.

THE “SO WHAT” TEST

For every bullet on your resume, ask “so what?” A bullet that survives the test ties a specific action to a measurable result. A bullet that doesn’t is a duty description, not an accomplishment.

FAILS

“Responsible for managing unit supply operations.”

PASSES

“Reduced equipment downtime 34%, recovering \$1.2M in operational costs, by redesigning the maintenance tracking workflow.”

Every bullet needs a number: dollar value, team size, error rate reduced, time saved, or throughput. No exact figure? Estimate conservatively and say “approximately.” Vague bullets get ignored.

Build Your Resume

Copy this structure directly and replace every bracket — this is the whole resume, ready to fill in. Two pages maximum, single column, no tables or graphics in the body once you're done — the applicant tracking system chokes on them.

[Your Full Name]

[City, State] · [Phone] · [Email] · [LinkedIn URL]

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

[2–4 sentences. Lead with what you deliver, not what you've done. Name your domain, your scale, and what you want to bring to a civilian team. No 'led,' 'managed,' 'oversaw,' or 'directed'.]

EXPERIENCE

[Civilian Job Title] · [Organization, City, State] · [Start–End Dates]

- [Action + measurable result. Run every bullet through the “so what” test — dollar value, team size, error rate, time saved, or throughput.]
- [Second quantified bullet.]
- [Third quantified bullet, if the role earns it.]

Repeat this block for each role, most recent first — 2–4 roles depending on career length.

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

[Degree, Institution, Date] · [Certification (Issuing Body)] · [Certification (Issuing Body)]

SKILLS

[Exact language pulled from your target job postings — tools, platforms, methodologies.]

AI PROMPTS FOR YOUR RESUME

Use these two prompts in ChatGPT, Claude, or Copilot. Paste your background and the target job description, and the AI will produce civilian-ready language. Both prompts deliberately avoid the verbs 'led,' 'managed,' 'oversaw,' and 'directed' — they push the AI toward outcomes instead of roles.

AI PROMPT — PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

"I am a transitioning U.S. [branch] veteran with [MOS/Rating/AFSC] experience. Here is the job description I am applying for: [paste]. Rewrite my resume summary to match this role in civilian language. Pull only from my resume to show how I am a strong fit. Lead with measurable results — improvements, savings, deliveries, throughput. Do not use the verbs 'led,' 'managed,' 'oversaw,' or 'directed'. Do not use filler language. Keep it under 3 sentences."

AI PROMPT — EXPERIENCE BULLETS

"You will act as a recruiter reviewing my resume and editing my experience bullets. Here is the job description I'm targeting: [paste]. Use this structure for every bullet: (1) the result or impact I had on the organization, (2) the skills, systems, or certifications from my resume I used to achieve it, (3) the end result or problem solved. Keep each bullet under one sentence. Do not use the verbs 'led,' 'managed,' 'oversaw,' or 'directed', or other words that don't convey measurable achievement — instead, open every bullet with a results-oriented word: saved, cut, reduced, built, secured, automated, scaled, delivered, increased, improved, or similar. Use quantifiable data (% , \$) pulled from my work experience below wherever possible. For the 'skills' part, name an actual system, technology, or process — not just a generic tool like AWS or a framework like PMP. Skills/certifications from resume: [insert here]. Previous work experience: [insert here]."

Example Resume

Read this first. This is what a resume that passes the “so what” test actually looks like.

John Doe

Boise, ID · (208) 555-5555 · j.doe@email.com · linkedin.com/in/johndoe

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Background running large, high-stakes logistics and operational programs where decisions carried real consequences — combining traditional supply chain expertise with AI and data tools to remove bottlenecks and improve forecasting. Looking to bring that blend of experience and innovation to a team that values efficiency, accuracy, and forward-leaning problem-solving.

EXPERIENCE

Operations Supervisor / Brigade Logistics Officer · U.S. Army, Fort Carson, CO · 2018–2026

- Reduced equipment downtime 34% (recovering \$1.2M) by redesigning the maintenance tracking workflow — built an ERP and SharePoint dashboard flagging at-risk assets 72 hours out.
- Delivered a \$4.7M inventory reconciliation 11 days early by applying Lean process mapping to cut 6 redundant approval steps and consolidate 3 ordering queues into one.
- Cut fuel spend \$210K annually by restructuring distribution schedules, consolidating 38% of weekly runs across 14 teams using TMS route analytics.

Logistics Coordinator / Maintenance Platoon Leader · U.S. Army, Fort Bragg, NC · 2015–2018

- Cut inventory discrepancies 22% in the first quarter by designing a tracking SOP and Kanban board later adopted org-wide.
- Improved equipment transfer time 60% (14 days to 5.5) and saved \$2.5M over 6 months by rebuilding the process in ERP inventory software.

EDUCATION

M.S. Supply Chain Management, [University Name] — expected 2027 · B.S. Business Administration (Logistics & Supply Chain), American Military University · Logistics & Supply Chain Operations, Army Sustainment University

CERTIFICATIONS

PMP (PMI, 2026) · Lean Six Sigma Green Belt ([Issuing Org], 2025) · Positioning SAP Business AI (SAP, 2024) · GenAI for Supply Chain Optimization (Coursera, 2026) · Oracle Fusion AI Agent Studio Certified Foundations Associate (Oracle, 2024) · Supply Chain Analytics Specialization, Rutgers/Coursera (in progress)

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Project Management: PMP methodology, WBS, risk register, MS Project, Smartsheet, Asana, Jira, Monday.com

Supply Chain & Logistics: demand planning, inventory management, procurement & vendor coordination, TMS

Process Improvement: Lean Six Sigma, value stream mapping, Kaizen, Kanban, 5S, SOP development

Data & Reporting: Excel (Power Query, Pivot, XLOOKUP), Power BI, Tableau, SQL, KPI dashboards

AI & Generative AI: Perplexity AI, prompt engineering, RAG fundamentals, AI-assisted forecasting & report drafting

Automation & Emerging Tech: Power Automate, Power Apps, Zapier, Make, process mining, workflow automation

Cover Letter Template

Fill in every bracket using your own words. The structure never changes — their mission first, then the bridge, then the payoff, then a short close.

[Your Name] [your.email@example.com] [(555) 555-5555] [City, State] [Date]

Dear [Hiring Manager name, or "Hiring Team" if you can't find it],

PARAGRAPH 1 — WHY THIS COMPANY, WHY NOW

HOW TO WRITE THIS PART: Open with THEM, not you. Name the specific thing the company is building or the problem they are solving, and say plainly what pulled you toward it. This first sentence proves you researched them and are not mass-applying. Do not mention yourself yet.

[Company] is [describe what they do or are building, in one specific phrase — a product, a mission, a problem they're solving]. That work caught my attention because [say plainly why it matters to you]. When I read that [name a specific detail — a recent project, a value they state, a direction they're heading], I knew this was a mission I wanted to help move forward.

PARAGRAPH 2 — WHY IT RESONATES WITH YOU

HOW TO WRITE THIS PART: Bridge their mission to your story. Your military or personal background shows up here as the REASON their mission resonates, not as a list of your duties.

That mission lines up with where I've already spent my energy. During [your service or recent experience, in plain civilian words], I [describe a real situation that connects to their mission]. It taught me [the lesson or conviction that now draws you to this company's work]. Helping a team like yours solve that at scale is exactly the work I want to be doing.

PARAGRAPH 3 — THE IMPACT YOU CAN HAVE ON THEIR MISSION

HOW TO WRITE THIS PART: This is the payoff. Show the concrete value you bring and tie it directly to their goals. Use a real result with a number if you have one.

Here is what I would bring to that work. At [previous role, company, or unit], I [a specific accomplishment with a result and a number]. I'm strong at [one or two skills that directly serve their mission], and I'd put that to work on [the specific challenge or goal of theirs you'd help with]. My aim would be simple: [the outcome you'd drive for them].

PARAGRAPH 4 — CLOSE WITH SHARED PURPOSE

HOW TO WRITE THIS PART: Keep it short and forward-looking. Thank them, restate your interest in THEIR mission in one line, and invite the next step.

Thank you for considering my application. I'd welcome the chance to talk about how I can help [Company] [restate their mission in a few words]. I'm ready to get to work.

Sincerely,
[Your Name]

Before You Send It

Run your letter against this list before it goes out.

- ☐ The first sentence is about the company, not about you.
- ☐ You named something specific about them that proves you did your research.
- ☐ Your background appears as the reason their mission resonates, not as a duty list.
- ☐ At least one accomplishment has a real number attached.
- ☐ You replaced every gold bracket and deleted these instruction notes.
- ☐ It fits on one page and reads in under a minute.
- ☐ You avoided the verbs led, managed, oversaw, and directed in favor of words that show a result.

THE PATTERN TO COPY

Strip away the specifics and the shape is simple: their mission, then why it resonates with you, then the impact you can have on it, then a short close. If your first sentence is about you, rewrite it. The whole letter answers one question for the reader: how does hiring this person move our mission forward?

A Cover Letter That Leads With the Mission

A former Army logistics NCO applying to a regional trucking company. Read the letter first, then the notes after each paragraph to see why it works. Notice what it never does: it never opens with what the applicant wants, and it never lists duties.

John Doe john.doe@email.com (210) 555-0147 San Antonio, TX March 4, 2026

Dear Hiring Team,

Redline Freight is rebuilding regional trucking around predictable, on-time delivery instead of the lowest possible bid, and you are doing it in markets the big carriers have written off. That caught my attention because I spent six years keeping supply moving in places where late was not an option and excuses did not help anyone. When I read that Redline is opening three new terminals in the Southwest this year and staffing them with people who can build operations from the ground up, I knew this was a mission I wanted to help carry.

WHY THIS WORKS: The first sentence is entirely about Redline, not John. It names something specific — rebuilding regional trucking around reliability, opening Southwest terminals — that proves he actually researched them. His own background only shows up as the reason their mission resonates.

That focus on reliability is exactly the work I care about. In the Army, I ran the supply operation for a unit of roughly four hundred people, often in remote locations where a single missed delivery could stop everything. I learned that on-time is not luck. It is the result of clear systems, honest tracking, and people who own the outcome. Building that kind of dependable operation in a brand-new terminal, for a company that has made reliability its whole promise, is the work I want to be doing next.

WHY THIS WORKS: This bridges his service to their mission. The military experience appears as the reason Redline's promise resonates, not as a duty list. He translates everything into plain civilian language and ties the lesson he learned directly to what the company sells.

Here is what I would bring to one of those new terminals. In my last assignment, I cut average resupply time by 31 percent by mapping out where the delays actually happened and fixing the three steps that caused most of them. I am strong at standing up a process from nothing and getting a team to trust it, which is exactly what a new terminal needs in its first year. My aim would be simple: get your Southwest terminals hitting their on-time targets faster than the plan expects, so Redline's reputation for reliability holds even as you grow.

WHY THIS WORKS: The payoff. It opens with a real, quantified result (cut resupply time 31 percent) and ties his skill directly to their specific challenge. The closing line states the outcome in terms Redline cares about — their on-time reputation — not in terms of what John wants.

Thank you for considering my application. I would welcome the chance to talk about how I can help Redline make on-time delivery the standard in markets everyone else gave up on. I am ready to get to work.

WHY THIS WORKS: Short and forward-looking. It thanks them, restates their mission in one vivid line, and closes with quiet confidence. No rehashing the resume, no begging.

Sincerely,
John Doe

Use AI to Sharpen It, Not Write It

Do not ask AI to write your cover letter. It will hand you the same generic, you-first letter every other applicant turns in. Use it as a force multiplier on work you drive. These three prompts keep you in the driver's seat.

1 · RESEARCH THE COMPANY (RUN THIS FIRST)

Best in Perplexity, because it cites sources you can check.

"I'm applying to [Company] for a [role] position. Act as a research assistant. Tell me, with sources I can verify: what is this company actually building or trying to do right now, what have they said publicly about their mission or values, and what recent news, projects, or changes are they working on? Give me three specific things I could genuinely reference in a cover letter to show I've done my homework. Do not make anything up. If you're not sure, say so."

2 · CRITIQUE THE DRAFT YOU WROTE

Use this on a letter you've already drafted. It edits your work instead of replacing it.

"Here is a cover letter I wrote: [paste]. The job is [role] at [Company]. Critique it against four rules. One, the first sentence should be about the company, not about me. Two, my background should appear as the reason their mission resonates, not as a list of my duties. Three, there should be at least one specific accomplishment with a real number. Four, it should avoid the verbs led, managed, oversaw, and directed. Point out exactly where I break each rule and suggest a fix, but do not rewrite the whole letter. Keep my voice."

3 · UNSTICK ONE PARAGRAPH

When the opening is the part that won't come, this gives you options to react to.

"I'm stuck on the opening of a cover letter for [role] at [Company]. Here's what I know about them: [paste a fact or two]. Here's my background: [one sentence]. Write me three different opening sentences that lead with what the company is doing and why it matters, not with what I want. Keep each to one or two sentences, plain language, no buzzwords."

WANT THE BLANK VERSION?

The Cover Letter Template earlier in this chapter walks you through this exact structure, with a "how to write this part" prompt for every paragraph. Copy it, replace every bracket, and run it through the critique prompt above before you send it.

CHAPTER 5

Interview Preparation

You've debriefed missions and written AARs — or sat through enough of your service member's to know the drill. Either way, you already know the STAR method, you just haven't applied it to interviews yet. Fill this out once. Walk into every interview ready.

The STAR Method & The Three T's

STAR stands for Situation, Task, Action, Result. Almost every question that starts with “tell me about a time when...” is asking for a STAR story. You’ve been telling them your whole career — in AARs, counseling sessions, award write-ups. The difference now: your audience doesn’t know what a FOB is. Translate the setting, not the skill.

THE THREE T'S — EVERY STORY MUST PASS ALL THREE

TRUE

A real story you can speak to under follow-up questions.

TIGHT

Under three minutes total — a minute on situation and task combined, a minute on action, a minute on result. What you did and the impact, not the buildup.

TIED TO THE ROLE

Chosen because it proves something this job actually needs.

EXAMPLE — SUPPLY & LOGISTICS BACKGROUND, TARGETING OPERATIONS

Situation	Inventory numbers looked off before a three-month overseas assignment — being short on critical parts wasn't an option.
Task	Verify roughly \$2M in parts and equipment inventory before the deadline.
Action	Chose to run a full hands-on count instead of trusting the system records; when it turned up 47 mismatches, decided to loop in purchasing and suppliers directly instead of waiting on the standard reconciliation cycle.
Result	The unit deployed on schedule with 100% of equipment verified — avoiding the two-week mission delay a shortage would have caused.

Types of Interviews

You apply, you wait, and then they call to schedule an interview. Depending on how often you've changed jobs, you may not be comfortable with the format — here's what to expect.

TYPE	WHAT TO KNOW
Phone Screen	Usually the first touch, often with a recruiter checking basic qualifications and culture fit. Quiet space, good reception, notes ready.
Virtual Interview	Treat it with the same professionalism as in-person — dressed fully, not just from the waist up, in a quiet space free of distractions.
Pre-Recorded Video	You get questions and a deadline to record answers. One-way, but just as serious as a live interview — prepare and research the same way.
In-Person	Could be a recruiter, a hiring manager, or a panel. Confirm who you're meeting and how long to expect beforehand.

BEFORE ANY FORMAT

Confirm the time, the format, and the location or link in writing. Know the interviewer's name. Have your resume and the job description in front of you.

Your STAR Story Bank

Build stories covering leadership, problem-solving, conflict, failure/recovery, and initiative — those five themes cover most behavioral questions. Four to start; the full 10-story workbook is at thesuccessfulvet.com.

STORY 1	
Title	
Situation	
Task	
Action	
Result	
Theme	Leadership · Problem-Solving · Conflict · Failure/Recovery · Initiative · Teamwork

STORY 2	
Title	
Situation	
Task	
Action	
Result	
Theme	Leadership · Problem-Solving · Conflict · Failure/Recovery · Initiative · Teamwork

STORY 3	
Title	
Situation	
Task	
Action	
Result	
Theme	Leadership · Problem-Solving · Conflict · Failure/Recovery · Initiative · Teamwork

STORY 4	
Title	
Situation	
Task	
Action	
Result	
Theme	Leadership · Problem-Solving · Conflict · Failure/Recovery · Initiative · Teamwork

AI PROMPT — STAR STORY BUILDER

"I am a transitioning U.S. [branch] veteran interviewing for [role] at [company]. Here's a situation from my career: [paste]. Turn it into a STAR answer, civilian-friendly, under 3 minutes spoken total — about a minute combined on situation and task, a minute on action, a minute on result. Keep the situation and task brief; spend the weight of the answer on what I did and the impact. Make the Result section entirely about impact — what I saved, reduced, improved, built, impacted, or implemented — with a number attached wherever possible. No 'led,' 'managed,' 'oversaw,' or 'directed.'"

WHAT EACH ROW MEANS

Situation — What was the context? Where, when, what was happening?

Task — What were YOU specifically responsible for in that situation?

Action — What did YOU do? Be specific — steps, decisions, tools used.

Result — What happened? Quantify if possible — numbers, %, \$, time saved.

Communication & Company Research

How you say it matters almost as much as what you say. Pair that with knowing the company's own language before you walk in, and you sound like someone who already belongs there.

COMMUNICATION THAT LANDS

- ☐ Pace yourself. Nerves speed people up — slow down and let pauses breathe instead of filling them with “um” or “like.”
- ☐ Translate the setting, not the skill. Say “a 400-person supply operation,” not your unit's MTOE.
- ☐ Read the interviewer's tone in the first two minutes and match their energy and formality.
- ☐ On video, look at the camera when you're delivering your key point, not the screen.
- ☐ If a question is vague, ask one clarifying question before answering — it shows you listen before you speak.

RESEARCH THEIR CORE BEFORE YOU WALK IN

Many behavioral and culture-fit questions are quietly testing whether your answers align with the company's stated mission, vision, values, pillars, or leadership principles. Find them — usually on the “About” or “Careers” page — and have one story from your bank ready that speaks directly to one of them.

AI PROMPT — DECODE THEIR CORE VALUES

“Research [Company]'s stated mission, vision, values, and any named leadership principles or cultural pillars. List each one exactly as they phrase it, with a one-line plain-English translation. For each, suggest one story from my background that speaks to it. Use sources I can verify — if you can't find something, say so instead of guessing.”

Amazon's Leadership Principles are the most famous version of this, but most large companies now publish something similar. Assume you'll be asked about at least one directly.

Behavioral Questions, Mapped

Match each question below to one of your STAR stories. The full 30-question bank is in the Interview Prep STAR Workbook at thesuccessfulvet.com.

LEADERSHIP

QUESTION	MY STORY #
Tell me about a time you led a team through a difficult situation.	
Describe a time you made a difficult decision with incomplete information.	
Tell me about a time you motivated a struggling team.	

PROBLEM-SOLVING

QUESTION	MY STORY #
Tell me about a time you solved a problem before it became a crisis.	
Describe a creative solution you found with limited resources.	
Tell me about a time a plan failed and what you did.	

COMMUNICATION

QUESTION	MY STORY #
Tell me about a time you had to deliver bad news to leadership.	
Describe a time you adjusted your communication style for an audience.	
Tell me about a conflict with a colleague and how you resolved it.	

ADAPTABILITY

QUESTION	MY STORY #
Tell me about a time you adapted quickly to a major change.	
Describe a time you worked effectively under pressure.	
Give an example of handling multiple priorities at once.	

TEAMWORK & INITIATIVE

QUESTION	MY STORY #
Tell me about a time you helped a struggling teammate.	
Describe your greatest professional accomplishment.	
Tell me about a time you took ownership of a problem that wasn't yours.	

Pre-Interview Checklist

RUN THIS BEFORE EVERY INTERVIEW

- ☐ Researched the company — mission, recent news, 2–3 facts to reference.
- ☐ Researched the role — know exactly what they need and how I map to it.
- ☐ Identified which stories from my bank are most relevant to this role.
- ☐ Ran a mock interview using the AI Mock Interview prompt.
- ☐ Prepared 3 closing questions to ask the interviewer.
- ☐ Checked the interviewer's name and LinkedIn.
- ☐ Confirmed interview time, format, and location or link.
- ☐ Completed a final 2-minute confidence brief: who I am, what I bring, why this role.

FREE PLACES TO PRACTICE — DON'T PAY BEFORE YOU'VE USED THESE

- **Skillora.ai** — free AI-led mock interviews, instant feedback.
- **Hire Heroes USA** — free one-on-one coaching and mock interviews.
- **American Corporate Partners (ACP)** — A free year-long mentorship; your mentor runs mock interviews with industry-specific feedback.
- **Candorful** — free live interview practice with real feedback.
- **USO Pathfinder** — free transition workshops and employment bootcamps.
- **Wounded Warrior Project** — free transition workshops and employment bootcamps.

THE THANK-YOU NOTE

Sent within 24 hours, to each person you interviewed with. Thank them specifically, reaffirm your interest, reinforce your single strongest reason you're a fit — and keep it a few sentences. This is a note, not another cover letter.

Your transition doesn't end with this page.

AI Mock Interview Tools

These are the current best free and paid tools to rehearse before the real thing.

TOOL	BEST FOR	INTERVIEW TYPE	KEY STRENGTHS
Skillora.ai	Realistic AI voice interviews	AI-led mock interviews	Resume-based interviews, dynamic follow-ups, instant feedback, role-specific questions
Final Round AI	End-to-end job prep	AI mock + real-time interview support	Interview copilot, ATS resume builder, detailed interview reports
Pramp	Real human interview experience	Live peer-to-peer interviews	Role rotation, real-time feedback, technical & behavioral rounds
Big Interview	Structured interview training	Video + mock practice	Expert-led lessons, video practice, communication improvement
Sapia.ai	Stress-free & inclusive interviews	Asynchronous chat & video	Bias-free evaluation, personality insights, coaching feedback
Talently.ai	Scalable hiring & screening	Live AI conversational interviews	Real-time scoring, automated scheduling, role-specific interviews
Interviewer.ai	Enterprise-level screening	Asynchronous AI video interviews	Explainable AI, content relevancy scoring, trusted by 850+ companies
Huru.ai	Video interview practice	AI-powered video mock interviews	Vocal & body language feedback, job-board integration

How to use this page — pick one AI tool and one human tool. Run at least three mock sessions with each before a real interview: one cold, one after reviewing your STAR stories, one after researching the company.

Source: Skillora, "Google Interview Warmup Is Gone: 8 Best Alternatives (2026)" — skillora.ai/blog/interview-warmup-alternatives

Quick Reference

Every download referenced in this workbook, in one place.

RESOURCE	WHERE TO FIND IT
Your book	The Successful Veteran – amazon.com/dp/B0DJL271C9
Free weekly content	thesuccessfulvet.com and thesuccessfulvet.substack.com
MOS Translation Worksheet	Full 5-branch crosswalk – thesuccessfulvet.com
LinkedIn Overhaul Checklist	Full 25-point audit – thesuccessfulvet.com
Veteran Resume Template	Full example + blank template – thesuccessfulvet.com
Interview Prep STAR Workbook	10 stories, 30 questions – thesuccessfulvet.com
SkillBridge	skillbridge.osd.mil
Onward to Opportunity	onwardtoopportunity.org

HASHTAG

#TheSuccessfulVet

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

CLOSING

You're Ready.

This workbook is the exercises. *The Successful Veteran* is the full playbook behind every page of it – the reasoning, the longer examples, and the complete pathway breakdowns for every certification track in Chapter 3.

Everything here, and everything at thesuccessfulvet.com, is free. Use the resources. Ask for help. When you land, come back and pay it forward to the next veteran or spouse figuring out where to start.

Andrew Miller

Author, *The Successful Veteran*

THESUCCESSFULVET.COM · #THESUCCESSFULVET